

The Trawler's Net

Do not set sail here. Do not even face the water. Keep your back to it. See my scales, my crushed hand, my useless arm. They are the fins of a trash fish. But you are a trophy. This I can tell. For I can tell a fish's value by its scales, and I have only been wrong once.

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I was, before, a trawlerman. A trade I'd learned in the employment of a commercial vessel in the Atlantic. Over many seasons, I lowered nets with powerful winches and discarded junk fish of all sorts whilst preserving those of highest value. Deep-sea prawns and silver schools of mackerel, and of course, the king of the catch — the Bluefin.

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I learned much from those days. But fate would discard me for the first time when negligent operation of the winch crushed my hand, carrying several fingers to the depths. This misfortune, however, introduced an opportunity in the form of a sizable settlement, which I

invested in a small but mighty coastal dragger and retreated to a docile but bustling fishing community. Here.

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To understand my tragic flaw, you must recognize that those years in the commercial industry made me, above all, a man of profit. So where the locals saw a lifestyle, I saw an industry.

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Before long, my more enterprising and efficient means had driven competing anglers from the markets. Indeed, many disapproved of how my nets indiscriminately swept the shoals and mid-depths for valuable fish and how I discarded the dismembered or otherwise junk fish I could not sell. But with the overwhelming quantities of what I brought to market, and at prices none could match, no sensible monger resisted.

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I had struck a vein of gold of which I was the sole prospector, and soon, there was not another vessel I could acknowledge with lights across the dark. I had become surrounded only by the untrustworthy sea and an endless miasma of dead or suffocating shitfish.

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But I did not stop, and I did not slow, and I hardly slept. I labored such that for all my wakefulness, I could not recount to you the calm serenity of sunset in those days, nor the gentle thawing of dawn. The demands of the lifestyle put me in a state beyond sound judgment. So when I fished her out of the sea, you mustn't blame me for not seeing immediately what she was.

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It was during a sleepless and moonless night that fate cast its line to me once more. I had spent the day sorting a lofty haul and was by-and-by loaded to the gunwales when the winch began an absurd screech. I hurried to the stern to aid the haul aboard. A wriggling tide of silver scales splattered across the deck, along with something else both strange and beautiful. It did not writhe with the rest of the catch, but moved in a way that expressed lively agitation such that I could tell she was not wholly a fish but not wholly human. It had a feminine figure, but I made note of its distinctly piscine qualities. Finned hands and feet, iridescent scales, and angular ears protruding from a gelatinous mess of hair.

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You may be thinking, as did I, that perhaps I'd netted a rare daughter of Nereus, or some other manner of nymph. But whatever her mythology, she was clearly a prize, a creature of some superstition of which I had irrevocable proof, and one thing felt certain: I could not merely sell her. She was too fine a trophy, and exposing her would draw fleets of commercial vessels to comb for another like her. So I confined her to a dark corner in my wheelhouse, where I appraised her as the finest thing I'd ever caught until sleep found me.

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I was stirred by what sounded like a dull foghorn in the distance. I must have slept through the day, because the moonless sky had given way to a crescent sliver. I hurried to the captain's window and peered into the night for the calling horn. Another boat perhaps? It had been so long. But in the dim light, I saw nothing. That's when I noticed her song for the first time.

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She sang something quiet and unpleasant from her corner. She had a dual-tone voice. A low, hypnotic, echoing drone — my foghorn no doubt — intertwined with an almost imperceptible lyrical muttering at a high octave in a language I did not think existed. It was something primordial, with many hard consonants in an unending rhythmless stream of syllables that sounded like what I can only describe as the sound of a chain dragging across the ocean floor. The faint moon shone such that I could now make out her fingers kneading and plucking long strands of seaweed from some source into a long braided rope.

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I determined to drag the nets whilst I pondered what to do with such a catch, failing to notice that first time how her song grew louder as the trawl-net dipped below the waves. Suddenly, the boat jerked to a halt as the motor roared and strained.

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I killed the engine, suspecting some line to be coiled in the prop. But to my astonishment, it was the violent splashing of a full net, burdened by a catch too heavy to tow. I hauled it aboard, unleashing an avalanche of sea denizens onto the mildew-stained deck. But despite the net's size, there was not a thing of value among the fins, tentacles, and muck. Bewildered, I lowered the trawl again, and this time, watched.

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It was an otherworldly sight. The very moment the trawl disappeared below the waves, the winch screamed against the sudden, rapid weight of a full net. I hauled it in and dumped yet another full bag of undesirable things. Cursing, I grabbed the deck broom and began heaving the entire suffocated mound back to the sea, when a crippling shriek forced the broom from my

hands. I instinctively clasped hands over ears, suspecting the winch had dropped a rogue chain, for the sound was indistinguishable. But when the screeching ceased, and I found the net unburdened, I resumed depositing the bycatch only to be crippled once more by a dreadful cry from the wheelhouse.

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Surely you must think me a fool, for I saw the wailing and my wastefulness a mere coincidence. It wasn't until several nights of pulling nothing but junkhauls did I realize I'd been given an unlucky curse to endlessly catch worthless things but not be able to discard them on account of her unbearable keening.

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I became nocturnal, working only by moonlight and sleeping through what day's rays might have calmed my growing nerves. I did not return to port for fear some monger might hear her disturbing melodies. But I could think of no alternative to what to do with her. My greatest catch had put me in a state of complete paralysis, and everything onboard suffered for it. Whatever I had caught that hadn't been bled or brined went rancid in a week. And all while I turmoiled, she continued to sing and weave her rope into a larger work of intersecting cords. At times, I found myself staring at those hands in both amazement and envy, imitating her deft movements with my crushed fingers. Soon her loom encroached on every corner of the boat, and before the end of a month, my inability to heave any trash fish overboard without losing consciousness from her screams amounted to mounds of liquifying fish over the deck, smothered all in a blanket of interlocked seaweed that flowed endlessly from the wheelhouse.

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Surely, you must wonder why I did not cut my losses then and return to port. I assure you, I came close. But it did not occur to me that this thing I'd caught had, in fact, caught me. The realization did not strike me until one night: the last night.

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The deck now glowed with the unnatural hue of a complete blood moon, casting unnerving shadows over every dead thing and feasting seabird. I crawled in its red glow, wading elbow deep in a hellish mire of ammonia-wafting decay. Her weave had become so large it now draped over every rail and trailed the boat in the sea below.

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I was starving, and sensible enough to know I could not stay at sea any longer. But not sensible enough to avoid trying one final time for a single, clean pull of the trawl to revive my failing mind. A mind that was in no state to operate the heavy winch.

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That boat drove on its own, but I thought nothing of it. Delirious, I deployed the net, and the wheelhouse grew loud in response. The net fell like a ball and chain, and was immediately swarmed by every stupefied junk creature to be enticed by her call. I should have disengaged the mechanism or tried to dump the weight as it amassed, but I let it drag until it became so great the whole stern started to sink. Then, a long creak gave way to a violent eruption as the winch broke from its mounts, bruising the deck and wrecking all in its path overboard.

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The damage was monumental. I rifled through the carnage, my hands fumbling in the tangles of sea-braids as I tried to sort the shrapnel and reassemble the boat from pieces of my

stupidity. But as I explored the deck, something undeniably familiar caught my eye. Aboard my vessel, the carcasses of a fish of fortune. The remains of dozens and dozens of Bluefin.

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I think I wept. Had they always been there? Surely I would have seen. Or had she stalked the deck in my sleep, dredging the sea with the net she'd woven to lure the finest things whilst I suffered? I would take no more. This hell siren had affronted me greatly. I would sell her for a fortune or for next to nothing; it no longer mattered. I'd dump her overboard along with any memory of her. I'd carve out her vocal cords.

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Brandishing a marlinspike with stubby fingers, I charged into the wheelhouse, reaching around the corner and thrusting blindly. The corner was empty. Suddenly, I was sent reeling, my foot caught in one of the many sections of her net. The spike fumbled inward as I fell, puncturing between my shoulder and pectoral and unraveling the sinews of muscles there like knots in the rigging.

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I shouted, but it was drowned entirely by her mind-numbing banshee call, unmistakable from the sound of a heavy chain dropping to the depths at hellish speed. The creature whom I'd once appraised as the most valuable of the sea had left her dark corner and was now seated at the helm. And fully lit by Selene's Chariot, I could see for the first time all that she had ever been.

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Her iridescent scales were nothing more than a putrid glaze of decaying fish flesh. Her eyes had the milky color of a long-dead thing. And what she wove came not from some invisible source, but from her own hair: a grotesque sea-weed net in which I'd become the bycatch.

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I do not know the events that enabled me to remove myself from that entanglement. But soon I was leaping head-first into the cold, brackish water, evading her long casting net and the allure of a hum and incantation meant to entice all of my kind until I made it ashore.

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And so I do not face the sea anymore. Nor should you. I remain a permanent fixture of this creaking dock. A trash fish, discarded with the muck. Do not set sail here. Resist the call of a distant foghorn. For you would be a prized catch in the trawler's net. I know a trophy by its scales. And I've only ever been wrong. Once.